Final statement and recommendations

Under the auspices of the Prime Minister Eng. Naji Ottari and General Secretary of the Arab League Mr. Amr Mousa, the First Edition of the Euro Arab Conference to Support SMEs was held in Damascus during 20-22 Feb. 2010 in cooperation between Syrian Enterprise and Business Centre/ SEBC and the Arab Organization for Industrial Development and Mining funded by the EU and the Arab Union for Engineering Industries/AIDMO.

We in particular, Rateb Al Shallah, SEBC Chairman and Mohammed Bin Yusef, General Director of AIDMO, and all participants in the Conference would like to express our appreciation and gratitude to the President, government and people of the Syrian Arab Republic for the great support exerted to hold this Conference, which will strengthen cooperation in this key sector in both regions, and also for the hospitality and fine reception.

The Conference was held amid the global financial crisis, which had deep impact on our economies. The effects of this crisis and its repercussions require mutual cooperation and coordination of efforts and a harmonization of visions and ideas.

The Conference aimed to widen scope of cooperation and partnership between Arab countries and the EU in the SMEs sector and achieve maximum benefit from the programs and funds launched by the countries on both sides in order to develop SMEs, boost their competitiveness, enhance their exports in order to be part of the global production network, transfer European technology to Arab countries and stimulate joint Arab-Euro industrial investments in the SMEs sector.

The Conference's agenda addressed a number of vital topics such as the current condition of SMEs in light of the demands of globalization and the global economic crisis, contribution of EU and Arab countries to support SMEs (presenting the case of EU and Arab Mashreq), role of the EU and Arab countries in supporting SMEs (presenting the case of Arab Maghreb countries and Gulf countries and the European Neighborhood Policy and its impact on SMEs through supporting entrepreneurship and innovation in Europe and the Arab World) and SMEs between competition and competitiveness.

The agenda also included the presentation of various working papers by Arab and European agencies and experts and valuable and constructive interventions, in addition to a number of bilateral meetings between participants.

The participants – more than 550 from 30 Arab and European countries – stressed that such gatherings will undoubtedly support the inter Euro-Arab economic, industrial, investment and commercial relations, will open the door for mutual cooperation in the SMEs sector and will boost the socioeconomic development growth rate in the two regions.

Recommendations and results

1. Establish the Arab-Euro Business Council as mechanism to follow up and implement the content of the final statement of the Conference and also the activities related to the relevant projects.
2. Establish a center to boost Arab exports to EU countries from SMEs products, and expressed their appreciation to the European Commission for allocating 500,000 Euros for mutual cooperation purposes.
3. The participants examined the role of human development in the field of developing SMEs leaders and personnel and expressed the importance of activating training and qualifying in this field.
4. The participants underlined the importance of creativity and innovation by linking creative persons with potential investors via the incubator networks and new enterprises' support centers.
5. The participants underlined the importance of benefiting from the Euro-Arab liaison office created in Malta by the European Commission, Arab League and Maltese Government to support SMEs.
6. The participants underlined the importance of facilitating SMEs access to the available financing products by disseminating the relevant information in order to improve the access mechanisms via the existing networks.
7. The participants expressed their appreciation of the role of the Arab League and its secretary-general Mr. Amr Mousa for sponsoring the Conference and stressed the importance of communication and coordination with the Arab League's General Secretariat.
8. The participants expressed their appreciation of the role and aid of the Arab League and European Commission provided for the Palestinian people underlying that the priority of the Conference in the future will be supporting SMEs in Palestine.
9. The participants agreed to hold the second edition of the Euro Arab Conference in the beginning of 2011 and once more expressed their appreciation and gratitude to the President, government and people of the Syrian Arab Republic for their hospitality and well reception, thanking in particular the Prime Minister Eng. Naji Ottari and Secretary- General of the Arab League Mr. Amr Mousa for their joint sponsorship.
10. On the occasion of holding the Conference, a memorandum of cooperation was signed between SEBC the Arab Organization for Industrial Development and Mining